

fare better than Novell in terms of market value.”

Vouching for RHCE's stronger reputation, Sudhir Bhaskaran, head, global learning services (GLS), Red Hat, says: “An RHCE is the only composite certification that reasonably checks the individual's know-how on Linux-based systems and network administration, with an eye on security aspects. Since the RHCE is multi-skilled on systems, networks and security parameters, certification from Red Hat is valued the highest in India.”

However, professionals with a more global exposure report that overall, Novell and Red Hat enjoy market dominance in different parts of the world. “It is just that RHCE is very popular in America and Asia, while Novell certifications provide tremendous value-add in the European continent. Thus, choosing between the two depends on where in the world a person plans to work,” says Prasad. “With SUSE's interoperable features, and .NET support on Linux, the market value of NCLP too is growing at a very high rate,” adds Manmohan Maniyar, an NCLP and RHCE certified professional.

Rohit Aggarwal, CEO, Koenig Solutions (a pioneer in offshore IT training and certification, offering both Red Hat and Novell certification), says: “Red Hat certifications are more in demand in comparison with Novell certification, but then again, it depends on the set-up in use [at a potential employer's site]. If a company uses SUSE Linux Enterprise Server, they will prefer Novell SUSE-certified professionals instead of those who are Red Hat certified.”

Technical strength: Who scores higher?

Shell scripting—writing scripts for the shell or command-line interpreter of an operating system—is a very important part of a systems administrator's work. Automating repetitive tasks with shell scripting leads to higher efficiency and productivity. NCLP focuses on Bash shell scripting, which is not covered in RHCE, giving Novell certified professionals an edge on the technical knowledge front. “The NCLP certification stands out by giving candidates the confidence to write their own

scripts. Confidence in shell scripting motivates people like me to learn other open source scripting languages, like Perl,” adds Natesh Sharan, a professional with both RHCE and NCLP certification.

Red Hat, on the other hand, offers an advantage in terms of knowledge about mail and proxy servers, which is not covered in NCLP. One needs another Novell certification called NCLE (in addition to NCLP) to attain such knowledge.

Red Hat promises career growth and makes professionals ready to face the competitive market. “RHCE along with CCNA (Cisco Certified Network Associate) improved my chances of getting more job offers with tremendous hikes, and gave me a very clear understanding of Linux. I strongly feel that RHCE has made me more confident to face the ever-growing cyber market,” says Jithu Thusi Chand, an RHCE-certified professional.

Further specialisation

Red Hat has a better-structured curriculum leading to higher levels of specialisation, compared to Novell. For example, if you are a professional pursuing a career in IT security, a combination of Red Hat Certified Security Specialist (RHCSS), Red Hat Enterprise Directory Services and Authentication and SELinux Policy Administration makes you a complete Linux security expert. Similarly, for data centre professionals, a combination of Red Hat Certified Data Centre Specialist with Deployment, Virtualisation and Systems Management, Directory Services and Authentication, Clustering and Storage Management provides the required skill-set to be labelled a data centre expert. “I wanted to excel in the field of OS security and administration. Red Hat certifications were the most comprehensive and authoritative Linux certifications that helped me in becoming more specialised and satisfied my hunger for excellence in Linux. The Red Hat certification basket made me very confident of handling and solving even the most challenging situations,” vouches Tejas Sevak, an RHCA (Red Hat Certified Architect),



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